

Chapter 18

The Stories

To generate the initial list of stories, the team decides to convene a story writing workshop where they will dedicate an hour or two to writing as many stories as they can. During a story writing workshop, one approach is to just write stories in any order regardless of which role or persona may act in the story. An alternative approach is to start with a specific user role or persona and write all the stories the team can think of before moving onto the next role or persona. The results should be the same with either approach. In this case the team discusses it and chooses to work through each role and persona.

Stories for Teresa

The team decides to start with Teresa, a persona identified in the previous chapter, since the team's customer member, Lori, has said that it is critical that the new website satisfy Teresa. The team knows Teresa is looking for speed and convenience. She's a true power user and will not mind a little extra complexity as long as the complexity helps her find what she's looking for more quickly. The first story they write is Story Card 18.1.

A user can search for books by author, title or ISBN number.

■ Story Card 18.1

The developers have some questions about this story. For example, can the user search by author, title and ISBN at the same time, or does Lori want them to search by only one criterion at a time? They let these questions sit for now and focus on getting more preliminary stories written down.

Next, Lori says that after searching for a book a user can see detailed information about a book. She gives a few examples of the type of information she means and then writes Story Card 18.2.

A user can view detailed information on a book. For example, number of pages, publication date and a brief description.

■ Story Card 18.2

There's probably more she'll want besides these three details but the developers can ask her later when they're ready to code this story.

As a typical eCommerce site, the team knows that users will need a "shopping cart" and that users will buy the books in their shopping carts. Lori the customer also says that a user will need the chance to delete books from the shopping cart before the order is processed. This leads to Story Card 18.3 and Story Card 18.4.

A user can put books into a "shopping cart" and buy them when she is done shopping.

■ Story Card 18.3

A user can remove books from her cart before completing an order.

■ Story Card 18.4

To actually process an order with a credit card, the system will need to know the credit card to charge and some address information. This leads to Story Card 18.5.

To buy a book the user enters her billing address, the shipping address and credit card information.

■ Story Card 18.5

Lori reminds the developers that since Teresa has only been sailing for four years, she won't always know exactly what book she wants. For Teresa the site should include features for customers to rate and review items. This leads Lori to write Story Card 18.6.

A user can rate and review books.

■ Story Card 18.6

Since Teresa wants to be able to order as quickly as possible, the team decides that the system needs to remember shipping and billing information. Some of the site's customers, for example the Non-Sailing Gift Buyer role, may not buy very often so these customers may not want to create a reusable account. Similarly, any extra steps the first time may scare off Captain Ron who is always a little tentative with new websites. So, Lori decides that a user can buy books with or without an account and writes Story Card 18.7 and Story Card 18.8.

A user can establish an account that remembers shipping and billing information.

■ Story Card 18.7

A user can edit her account information (credit card, shipping address, billing address and so on).

■ Story Card 18.8

The team also knows that Teresa wants to put items on a wish list of items she wants but is not ready to buy today. She'll either buy them for herself later or she'll tell her husband, Tom, and he'll buy items from her wish list. So, Lori writes Story Card 18.9 and Story Card 18.10.

We want to make sure that whoever programs Story Card 18.10 knows that a user can select items from her own or someone else's wish list. We make sure to note that on the card (parenthetically in this case).

A user can put books into a “wish list” that is visible to other site visitors.

■ Story Card 18.9

A user can place an item from a wish list (even someone else’s) into his or her shopping cart.

■ Story Card 18.10

Because speed will be important to Teresa, Lori also identifies a performance constraint relating to how long it takes to order a book. She writes Story Card 18.11.

*A repeat customer must be able to find one book and complete an order in less than 90 seconds.
(Constraint)*

■ Story Card 18.11

In this case Lori has chosen to focus on the time it takes a repeat customer to search for a book and complete her order. This is a good performance requirement because it captures all aspects of the user’s experience with the site. Blazing fast database queries and middleware don’t count for much if the user interface is so confusing to navigate that it takes a user three minutes to get to the search screen. This story reflects this better than would a story like “Searches must complete in two seconds.” Naturally, Lori can add more performance constraints but it is usually sufficient to pick a few broad ones like this story.

Stories for Captain Ron

It becomes clear that the team is running out of stories for Teresa, the Experienced Sailor. So, they agree to switch focus to Captain Ron, who runs a sailing school and is a little more tentative with computers than is Teresa. When Cap-

tain Ron comes to the site he typically knows exactly what he's looking for. This leads Lori to write Story Card 18.12 and Story Card 18.13.

A user can view a history of all of his past orders.

■ Story Card 18.12

A user can easily re-purchase items when viewing past orders.

■ Story Card 18.13

These stories will allow Captain Ron to look back at his old orders and repurchase items from those orders. However, Lori points out that Captain Ron may also want to purchase an item that he looked at recently, even if he hasn't previously purchased it. She writes Story Card 18.14.

The site always tells a shopper what the last 3 (?) items she viewed are and provides links back to them. (This works even between sessions.)

■ Story Card 18.14

Stories for a Novice Sailor

Next, the team moves on to consider the Novice Sailor role. The needs of a Novice Sailor largely overlap those of Teresa and Captain Ron. But Lori decides it would be helpful if a Novice Sailor could see a list of our recommendations. Here the Novice Sailor could find the books we recommend on a variety of topics. She writes Story Card 18.15.

A user can see what books we recommend on a variety of topics.

■ Story Card 18.15

Stories for a Non-Sailing Gift Buyer

Switching to the Non-Sailing Gift Buyer role, the team discusses how it must be easy for a shopper to find the wish list of another person. They start to discuss various design solutions and what fields will be used for searching until they remember that design discussions should be saved for later. Instead of designing the feature in this meeting, Lori writes Story Card 18.16.

A user, especially a Non-Sailing Gift Buyer, can easily find the wish lists of other users.

■ Story Card 18.16

Lori also knows that the system needs to support gift cards and wrapping. She writes Story Card 18.17 and Story Card 18.18.

A user can choose to have items gift wrapped.

■ Story Card 18.17

A user can choose to enclose a gift card and can write her own message for the card.

■ Story Card 18.18

Stories for a Report Viewer

Lori says that the system needs to generate reports on purchase and traffic patterns and so on. She hasn't yet thought about the reports in detail so the developers write a simple placeholder story that will remind them that there are reports to develop. They'll decide on the report contents later. For now she writes Story Card 18.19.

Thinking about reports reminds Lori that the reports are highly sensitive. Naturally, they won't be available from the main site that consumers see. But, she says that only certain people within the company can have access to the

A Report Viewer can see reports of daily purchases broken down by book category, traffic, best- and worst-selling books and so on.

■ Story Card 18.19

reports. This could mean that if you can access one report you can access them all, or it could mean some users can access only some reports. The developers don't ask Lori about that now and Lori writes Story Card 18.20.

A user must be properly authenticated before viewing reports.

■ Story Card 18.20

To make reports meaningful, Lori says that the database used by the website must be the same database used by our current telephone-based system. This leads Lori to write the constraint shown on Story Card 18.21.

*Orders made on the website have to end up in the same order database as telephone orders.
(Constraint)*

■ Story Card 18.21

Some Administration Stories

At this point attention shifts to the Administrator user role. The team thinks instantly of Story Card 18.22 and Story Card 18.23.

An administrator can add new books to the site.

■ Story Card 18.22

An administrator needs to approve or reject reviews before they're available on the site.

■ Story Card 18.23

The story about adding new books reminds them that administrators need to delete books and also edit books in case incorrect information was used when the book was added. So they write Story Card 18.24 and Story Card 18.25.

An administrator can delete a book.

■ Story Card 18.24

An administrator can edit the information about an existing book.

■ Story Card 18.25

Wrapping Up

By now Lori is starting to run out of stories. So far, each story has come instantly to mind but now she's having to think about whether there are any others. Because the project will be done using an incremental and iterative development process, it's not important that she think of every story right up front. But because she wants a preliminary estimate of how long the system will take to build, the team does want to think of as much as they can without spending an inordinate amount of time. If Lori comes up with a new story once we've started, she'll have the opportunity to move it into the release if she moves out the same approximate amount of work.

The developers ask Lori if there are any other stories she feels have been forgotten thus far. She writes Story Card 18.26.

Lori also reminds the developers that scalability needs are not tremendous but that the site does need to handle at least 50 concurrent users. They write this constraint on Story Card 18.27.

A user can check the status of her recent orders. If an order hasn't shipped, she can add or remove books, change the shipping method, the delivery address and the credit card.

■ Story Card 18.26

The system must support peak usage of up to 50 concurrent users.
(Constraint)

■ Story Card 18.27

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